Footprint of Education: Hao Yu

Hao Yu has participated in CAST-USA's Executive Leadership Committee as one of the Advisor-Presidents and a member of the AI Committee in Los Angeles. Born in Beijing, China, in 1972, he grew up in a competitive educational environment. Uncertain about his life and dreams as a child, he moved to the U.S. because his parents were immigrants, later discovering his path in education and advocacy for multicultural communities.

Hao's educational journey wasn't planned; it was unexpected, given his turbulent teenage years. In the interview, he expressed his past struggles with academics from middle school through junior college, which he eventually dropped out of before moving to the U.S. After moving to Los Angeles, he worked a tremendous range of jobs, including process server, plumber, and cashier, and his last full-time job was working as a tour guide with his roommate, who used almost all of their earnings together to pay Hao's tuition to study at Pasadena City College. At that time, his only two pathways and the voices around him were: selling T-shirts in Africa to earn a salary or believing that only education leads to success.

Continuing his journey from PCC to UCLA, Hao realized how education could change his life and how this system encouraged and energized students who felt excluded or discouraged by past academic experiences. From his roommate, his peer friends at PCC who motivated him to pursue a higher degree, professors and faculty who guided him beyond the classroom, and the universities themselves that helped him find jobs, Hao gained new cultural perspectives and generous, no-strings-attached support. He learned the importance of giving back to the system and the community he lived in, from feeling discouraged to regaining confidence through persistence, and finally becoming the person who can leave his "footprints" for younger generations to follow as he figured out his career path in CAST-USA. In this role, Hao aims to help more new Chinese immigrant students realize their value to society through self-development and achieve their personal value, as he quotes Confucius: "Education for all, regardless of background."

Interview

Please tell me your name and age

My name is Hao Yu, and I'm 54 years old.

Where are you from?

I'm from Beijing, China.

Can you share pieces of your Childhood or Teenage Experiences?

During my teenage years, I was in an academically competitive environment because we had to take one major exam after middle school that determined which high school you went to, and

another exam after high school that determined which university you went to.

When did you come to the U.S.?

I came to the U.S. in 1993.

Why did you make this transition? And what change came first?

This was not a personal decision. My parents immigrated from China to the U.S. to work here, but I lived in Beijing until I was 18, then dropped out of junior college to move to the U.S. for work and to reunite with my family.

Where and why did you continue your academic studies?

Generally speaking, I continued my academic career first at Pasadena City College and then at UCLA. But this route was very different from my original plan because I came here just to work and didn't go to school at first. I tried multiple jobs, almost twenty, including process server, plumber, and cashier, and I rented an apartment with my friend, who worked with me as a tour guide. He secretly used all of our savings to pay for my tuition at Pasadena City College, which helped and pushed me onto the right track, which is the academic route for me.

How is this environment different from Beijing?

The academic environment here is very different from the schools I attended in Beijing. In China, I wasn't academically talented, as I did poorly on "Gāo Kǎo", which is a college entrance examination you need to take after three years of high school, and I went to a junior college. At the time, my teachers and I all thought I wasn't the best fit academically, and I felt discouraged by this highly selective education system, since so many students compete with me. However, the professors here, the local government, and the institutions themselves, either PCC or UCLA, all wanted me to thrive by providing pathways to continue my education, help me find suitable work, and access federal aid.

How did it change you?

This system and this new cultural environment changed me both academically and socially. Academically speaking, I realized that through this journey of receiving generous help from various sources within the school system, I learned something beyond the classroom, which allowed me to think about why education matters and why we study. As I said before, I "chose" the second pathway that was offered to me when I first came to the U.S.

What were some obstacles that you encountered?

The obstacles I encountered mainly arose after school and when I first started my job. As with the last question, many misunderstandings stemmed from significant cultural differences between us. After joining CAST-USA, I observed that almost 70% of the Americans on my team communicate their concerns, problems, and suggestions directly and only about the task itself, not the person.

My Chinese colleagues, however, often found this difficult, as they have attached “personal pride” to the importance of maintaining stable relationships and fluid collaboration. So it was really hard for me to work as part of a team and coordinate with others while trying to manage potential conflicts.

And what is your perception of how it led you now?

I don’t think my perception of what happened has changed much, but I do consider that it has shaped my identity more. Working at CAST-USA, where I coordinate and work with both Chinese and American people, has strengthened my ability to adjust my thinking and speaking based on environmental changes, especially in my sense of propriety. This has also strengthened my insight, allowing me to make decisions from two critical perspectives.

As more and more younger generations of Chinese students, as well as people from all over the world, came to the U.S. to pursue either education or work, what is one place that you felt most representative to visit or advice to give?

Speaking of myself, I can almost be described as being abandoned academically by my parents and the education system in China, because it simply was not the right fit for me. However, I want all students on their journey to understand that if something doesn't suit you, try more, because opportunities are always waiting for you to find them. I could not have become an advocate for education without coming to the U.S. and, most importantly, finding my own way through life's currents. Another piece of advice I would give, again, not only to Chinese students but to all students, is to deal with the obstacles themselves, don’t drag personal issues into it, and learn that it is only towards the thing, not towards the people. Once, I saw a badminton court that didn’t allow Chinese people to play or rent the court; I found the owner and argued with them to fight for my right to play here, and I persuaded them to welcome us and remove the sign. You may think that after this conflict, we might both feel awkward talking or contacting each other again, but we are both people who reflect on our mistakes and don’t dwell on this conflict later. Therefore, I think that it is very important to focus on the things and not engage too much in future interactions once both sides have grown from the experience